



▲ SEGREGATION

Under apartheid, separate areas were created for each ethnic group. Facilities and areas for “non-whites”, such as this public toilet, were always worse than the “white-only” spaces. Black people had to carry passes in white areas and marriages between “whites” and “non-whites” was forbidden.

FACT

Steve Biko was a key figure in the fight against apartheid. He led several campaigns and founded the South African Students Organization to fight for the rights of Black students.

▼ GROUP AREAS ACT

In 1950, the South African government passed the “Group Areas Act,” a law that created different areas for each race. Thousands of Black people were later forced out of their homes to live in new areas called “homelands.”



The struggle against apartheid

A system known as apartheid (“separateness”) existed in South Africa from 1948 until the early 1990s. Under this system, Black people were discriminated against—they had fewer rights than white people, and faced restrictions on where they could live, go to school, and work.

Although the population of South Africa was mostly Black, the laws of apartheid gave white people control of the country and the power to set and enforce the laws. Black people were forced out of their homes and were not allowed to own businesses or land, live, travel, or work in certain areas. If they broke these laws, they were punished or sent to jail.

Many people were against apartheid and protests were led by the African National Congress (ANC). At first the protests were peaceful but as the government’s regime grew more brutal—more than 50 protesters were killed in the Sharpeville Massacre in the 1960s—the protests became more violent, too. But from the 1980s, increasing international pressure

highlighted the need for reform. In May 1994, Nelson Mandela—the leader of the ANC—was elected the first Black president of South Africa in the first elections in which Black people could vote, marking the end of apartheid.



▲ AFRICAN NATIONAL CONGRESS

The African National Congress (ANC), founded in 1912, became the leading group campaigning against apartheid. It was banned by the government from 1960 to 1990 and was forced to operate in secret during this period.

ALBERTINA SISULU

Albertina Sisulu (1918–2011) was one of the most famous activists of the anti-apartheid movement. She was the wife of ANC leader Walter Sisulu, and became known by many as “Ma Sisulu,” the mother of the nation.

